

Are the Deists Correct in their
Natural Interpretation of Religion?

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Are the Deists correct? Of all the worldviews that I've seen, Deists seem to have the most credible framework that gives a convincing argument - excluding Christianity - which we hope to be the most appealing since we believe and hope in it.

But the Deists have Locke and Benjamin Franklin and Thomas Jefferson as their advocates. Now who can go up against these guys? One of them is even a President of the United States. The Deists were generally Founders of America, but Locke was an Englishman.

Locke has an important influence on history. He created the Blank Slate theory - that babies are born with a blank slate, and are not evil nor good when they are born. He had a view that religion can be viewed scientifically - that the natural world explains all the functions of God.

And this is the perspective that I want to focus on in this essay - can the Deists be right in that natural revelation is enough to explain God? That special revelation is unnecessary?

And a secondary question is, "Is natural revelation necessary and always true in light of special revelation." What this means is that, "If God and the Bible says it, it is totally right! Don't think about it!" This question would say, "God and the Bible says it, but does our science and our natural understanding support it?" This is an important question because it could be very well that natural understanding should always support God and special revelation because God created nature.

The first source I will analyze is¹ regarding "natural religion." It's a special term, "natural religion," and it is totally pertinent to the topic that I focusing on. In the introduction of the article, it says, "Deism's legacy to the modern world is the scientific study of religion." You

¹ Wiebe, Donald. "Natural Religion and the Nature of Religion: The Legacy of Deism." *Method & Theory in the Study of Religion* 6, no. 1-4 (December 31, 1994): 92-104.

see, religion was viewed as a natural occurrence - not as a supernatural thing. It's like when we see an apple on an apple tree - it's totally normal and natural. Religion, can be viewed as an anthropological occurrence. It's like the apple on a tree - religion is totally normal. Deism would study religion as a scientific pursuit, and try to divorce it from the Bible or from supernatural things.

Is this different from Christianity? Extremely, yes. Deism is viewing religion as just some common thing, rather than a separate and holy thing. And it is viewing it as a natural occurrence, like light, rather than a God who says, "Let there be light." I want to emphasize that Deism must be wrong, because the Bible states that there is a supernatural aspect to the universe, and there is not just the created things that can be observed to come up with a theory of religion.

In fact, the article states that Deism and natural religion is a "theologically loaded picture of religious history." We see that Deism is not just making a small statement - it is making a very "loaded" image of religion. It is saying that all religious history is just a natural occurrence, and has no aspect of supernatural. It's like explaining the four seasons when Deism examines the religious history of the Jews, Roman Christians, Eastern Christians, etc.

We see that the "belief in the universality of religion (implying in turn that Christianity is comparable to the other religions)-all notions that are essential to the modern study of religion." This is an incredible statement in that all religions are unified in the study of the "universality of religion." This means that Christianity is just another religion, and has no specialty about it. All religion, even those of the pagans, are the same root and phenomenon as Christianity. And we see that this general view of religion is actually the plus side of Deism: the "global history of religions became a vehicle of religious revelation." We see that Deism believes that this global

and general view of religion leads to true knowledge and true revelation. This is contrasted with Christianity that specifically says that certain things like the Bible are special revelation.

From these quotes, we can determine that Deism is trying to create a natural religion and religious history that views religion as just a natural occurrence, and that Christianity is still alive and distinct when it says that the Bible is true and supernatural things exist.

The next article² shows that Deism is not a perfect system. We may read books that try to make history sound like some cookie-cutter formed history, but it is not so. We see from this article that Locke, one of the most famous Deists, finds the Bible to hold some special revelation. This is in contrast with the Deist view in that special revelation is not accepted and a natural religion is accepted as in the previous article.

What this article says is that Locke “stresses the need for divine revelation for ascertaining right moral principles.” It seems that Locke, who at times says that Deism is correct, is at times saying that Christianity and special revelation is necessary. “Locke appeals to the Bible (exoterically) while simultaneously trying to undercut its authority (esoterically).” This is extremely clear, according to the article, that Locke is “undercutting” Deism. He is appealing to the Bible.

The article claims “yet others, as alluded to above, take Locke’s claims in ROC, such as his assertion that a moral society needs the Bible and the Christian faith, as sincere, though they acknowledge that there are apparent, though not definitive, inconsistencies between his two noted works, not the least of which is indicated above.” This shows that it is true that there are

² Marko, Jonathan S. “The Promulgation of Right Morals: John Locke on the Church and the Christian as the Salvation of Society.” *Journal of Markets & Morality* 19, no. 1 (December 31, 2016): 41–59.

“inconsistencies” and that Locke was faltering between two worldviews. When we claim that Deism is true in some regards, we are not completely denying Christianity. We have to understand that worldviews are fluid, not solid.

The next article³ talks of Butler, who had a very strong view against Deism. If I am not mistaken, Butler was a Christian who was debating the Deists. This article essentially talks of how the Deists were strange in that they believed in God, but none of the theology, and that nature was the only theology related to God.

To quote the article explicitly, it says, “the Deists, against whom he levelled his arguments, believed in God and in little else. They rejected as superstitious additions to primitive faith, the cardinal dogmas of Christianity.” This shows that the Deists did not believe in the Bible - they believed in a rational and natural type of God. “Nature be conceived as coming from the hands of a beneficent Creator there are sufficient elements in deduction from admitted facts to justify the acceptance of Religion as credible.” This natural God is conceived as coming from a good Creator, but not a well-defined Creator. The information about the creator comes from “deduction” and not from religious texts.

And these Deists, according to Butler, would use "doubt which is one feature in 'The Meditations of Descartes.'" Doubt would be a way of making things look like they were very intellectual and very philosophically accurate about their understanding of God. However, according to the Bible, we know that God is much more intelligent than us. From this we see that the Deists and Christians are using philosophy as a common element to find out the truth, but

³ Hammond, T C. (Thomas Chatterton). “Butler’s Analogy, 1736-1936.” The Evangelical Quarterly 8, no. 4 (December 31, 1936): 337–55.

other things may differ. This means to me that the Deists are wrong; however, do a good job in being philosophically sound.

The next article⁴ is a slightly different approach. Instead of looking at things from a historical angle, this article looks at Deism in the lives of the youth today. If we want to have a good examination of an honest view of life - it is the youth of today. And what this article says is that Deism is alive and well today - the youth of America believe in Deism. The Deism that is defined in the article is a specific kind of deism that can be explained as 5 points below:

- 1) A god does exist who created and ordered the world and watches over human life on earth.
- 2) God wants people to be good, nice, and fair to each other, as taught in the Bible and by most world religions.
- 3) The central goal of life is to be happy and to feel good about oneself.
- 4) God does not need to be particularly involved in life except when God is needed to resolve a problem.
- 5) Good people go to heaven when they die.

From the list, we can all relate, as Americans, to this worldview. It is the general worldview that we all have as Americans, that “good people go to heaven when they die.” It’s the worldview that we have a good God over us who created the world, and we don’t even need this God really fully unless we have a serious issue. But this God has no theology, no character, and we don’t even care about this God.

⁴ Mattes, Mark C. “Jesus Christ and Moralistic Therapeutic Deism.” *Logia* 32, no. 1 (December 31, 2023): 31–36.

According to the author of the article, this Deism pervades most of the youth today. And we see that they are dying. According to this article, we see that that the youth do not have a Savior. According to the article, “to face our death and guilt, we need more than just a Great Teacher.” This is the limitation of Deism. Yes, Deism seems to be intellectually very sophisticated, looking at such wonders and inexplicable things as just a natural occurrence that can be explained. But the result? Deism results in dead youth. Youth who have no hope, and youth who have no Savior.

“We need a Savior. We need someone who can liberate us from death, sin, and hell. A band-aid religion that kisses our cuts and bruises but fails to raise us from the dead will not cut it.” We see that Deism will not provide Christ - Christ is not in Deism - Christ is in the Bible. “Everything about MTD or Benjamin Franklin's version of deism is to suggest that Christ is not necessary.”

The next article⁵ points out a feature in Spanish society - their unbelief in God. According to this next article, we find that that the belief and unbelief in God in Spanish society has been conditioned by several belief systems: agnosticism, deism, Christianity, and atheists. The exact list of four categories is below:

- 1) deists, who believe in a god or an all-powerful mind;
- 2) believers, who believe in God;

⁵ Herranz de Rafael, Gonzalo, and Juan S Fernández-Prados. “Explanation of the Trends and Recent Changes in Spanish Society Regarding Belief in God: Atheism, Agnosticism, Deism, Skepticism, and Belief.” *Religions* 13, no. 11 (December 31, 2022): 1–13. doi:10.3390/rel13111086.

3) agnostics or skeptics, who do not deny the existence of God, but either have doubts or point to its cognizable impossibility (Eller 2004); and

4) atheists, who do not believe in God

Although we would all agree that Spanish people generally believe in Christianity less than in the past, there seems to be still a remnant in Spanish society, as there is with most Western cultures in the world, of a Christian remnant. And so we see that the purpose of the article is to show that this belief and unbelief in Christianity has been due to big theological and cultural movements in history. “Spaniards’ denial or doubting of the existence of God is conditioned, to a greater extent, by their lives and socio-historical trajectory.” And one of the biggest players is Deism in this Spanish worldview.

According to this article, Deism was first conceptualized in Greece.

"Anaxagoras, the disciple of and successor to Anaximenes, was the first thinker who asserted that the orderly arrangement of the universe was designed and realized by the rational power of an infinite mind." And so as we can see, we see that Deism is characterized by rationalism and by a general approach to the definition of God. As Christians, we can see the history and pervasiveness of this thought, but we should always correct history with truth from the Bible.

The next article⁶ touches upon atheism and Deism, and shows that Deism can be viewed in a positive light. In this article, we find an argument between an atheist and a theist. The question is: “How can a God allow for evil?” And the article says, “When this grammar is examined, it becomes clear that this assumption cannot avoid the atheistic force of the argument

⁶ Hall, Ronald. “Compassionate Deism and the Grammar of Permission.” *Religions* 12, no. 3 (December 31, 2021): 1–9. doi:10.3390/rel12030200.

from evil. To rescue belief in God, I propose the adoption of a position I call compassionate deism.”

What we see is that the “atheistic force” of the argument of evil is very strong. How can a good God allow for evil? Is that not contradictory? Good allowing for evil? And what we see is a philosophical position that is called “compassionate deism,” that combines the views of all religions that hold to a God. This compassionate deism allows us to understand that although God may be good, he can allow for evil. And we also understand that Deism, although it has been viewed in a negative light this whole paper, actually has a positive side to it in this article, which shows that Deism supports a philosophical position in the problem of evil. This “compassionate deism,” defends against the “atheist’s denial of God’s goodness.”

And from this article we can deduce the many arguments for a good God allowing for evil. And none of these arguments have to come from Scripture. Any support from Scripture, regarding the problem of evil, will be specific to Christianity and will only support a philosophical argument for a good God. This compassionate deism will be able to support Christianity and deism - a general God. Scripture will help with unique approaches and views of the goodness of God, but this article is viewing from compassionate deism.

The next article⁷, the author makes a bold statement that has theatric appeal. She says, “Deism did not die after the Last English deist of the eighteenth century closed his eyes.” What this is saying is that Deism is not some theory that is held to some English philosophers in the eighteenth century - in contrast, Deism is a general idea that has been re-derived and re-instated throughout different cultures and different times. What this author is especially saying is that

⁷ Berg, Jan van den. “The Development of Modern Deism.” *Zeitschrift Für Religions- Und Geistesgeschichte* 71, no. 4 (December 31, 2019): 335–56.

Deism is believed in today. To be specific, she outlines 6 basis of beliefs of Deism that are held on to today (which she finds despicable):

- 1) the rejection of religious authorities,
- 2) the rejection of divine revelation,
- 3) the rejection of an interventionist God
- 4) a universal ecumenism,
- 5) a leaning towards cosmological models of explaining the world
- 6) sixth characteristic: the repulsion experienced towards the idea that a loving father accepts the death of his son as a basis for the salvation of mankind.

You see, people in this world find Deism fascinating because it rejects the traditional authorities and holds up a new solution - a natural interpretation of religion. This gets rid of the things that are viewed as childish and outlandish. It allows the carnal mind to be free and happy. By giving up the idea that the loving “father accepts the death of his son” as the basis for salvation, we give up everything. This love, although it seems specific and insignificant, is the actual love that saves us. It’s the love that shows God’s love for us. And if we reject this, we reject everything.

The purpose of my paper is to investigate if Deism is correct, and there are some ways that Deism is good - Deism supports a philosophical grounding that encompasses Christianity. But if Deism makes Christ invaluable and the Gospel no truth, then we see that Deism, although it has much value in a natural and scientific understanding of religion, is incorrect.

We see that the Great William Wilberforce - “politician (1759-1833) about his youth: ‘I was a deist for part of my time at Oxford’.” We see that even great politicians and great people

believed in Deism because Deism seems like it is rejecting tradition in a powerful and independent and high-browed way.

The next article⁸, deals with the great English author, William Blake. We understand William Blake to be a person who criticized other religions, and provided stories of what God is really like. In particular, William Blake “charges the Deists with a grave crime: not only are they the ‘Enemies of Christianity’; they are the enemies of the entire ‘Human Race’ in their ‘worship of the God of this World by the means of what [they] call Natural Religion and ... of Natural Morality or Self-Righteousness, the Selfish Virtues of the Natural Heart’”.

What this quote is really saying is that Christianity has brought so many good things into this world, and Deism is a “grave crime” against all of the different aspects and good natures of the Christianity. You see, Christianity has Righteousness, and Deism has Self-Righteousness and Natural Morality. Christianity has True Religion, and Deism has Natural Religion. Christianity has the Fruit of the Spirit, and Deism has “Selfish Virtues of the Natural Heart.”

As you can see, Deism is leveled out to be anti-Christianity because Deism is just a way to satisfy the carnal mind. You see, Deism is the natural man looking at a natural world, and he understands God to be something that can be observed and naturally interpreted. But if we truly understand the spiritual nature of the situation, it is as Romans 1 says, “that man, knowing the truth of God, suppressed the truth.” Romans 1 goes on to say that man fell into many carnal ways of thinking and sins. As you can see, this carnal mind is the same carnal mind of Deism.

⁸ Codsi, Stephanie. “‘Father, Father, Where Are You Going?’: Epicurean Deism and Absent Fathers in Blake’s Songs of Innocence and of Experience.” *Literature and Theology* 33, no. 4 (December 31, 2019): 357–75. doi:10.1093/litthe/frz028.

William Blake's flawed view of God can be seen in: "Epicureanism, or, more specifically, the Epicurean notion of atoms, and of God's relationship with man—or lack thereof." What we can see is that Epicureanism is the God of William Blake, and we see that although Blake has identified the problem with Deism, he fails to find a good solution. Deism, is similar to this God of Blake's because Deism has a general picture of God, and Blake views this God as the no-God of Epicureanism.

To provide a little bit of background, Epicureanism is about pleasure - it's about enjoying all the delights of life. And behind this is a God who is actually probably very bad. In Blake's writing, he creates a story where he creates this God to be "but a different sort of father to the tyrannical god-father typified by the likes of Urizen in other works. The absent father has received little critical attention, but he pervades Songs."

And we see that this Father who is absent, and uncaring, is not like the God of Yahweh. We see that the God of Israel cannot be compared to these little stories of Blake's or of the conceptions of Deism. The conceptions of man will never be able to create the conception of God that special revelation can. We will see Deism make a strong approach to correctness, only utterly failing because it is man's approach to God rather than God's approach to man.

In the next article⁹, we see a philosopher who is trying to combine these two things in his head: deism (which he finds plausible through epistemology), and this type of theism that he is familiar with through Christianity.

Although, I do not know the exact reason behind this paper, it can be thought that one possible purpose is to resolve a philosopher's epistemology regarding God (which can lean

⁹ Łukasiewicz, Dariusz. "Epistemic Deism and Probabilistic Theism." *European Journal for Philosophy of Religion* 10, no. 1 (December 31, 2018): 129–40.

toward “epistemic Deism,” as called in this paper), and the Christian God that he may have been raised with.

This paper seems to explain that the “conceptions of epistemic deism and probabilistic theism and to demonstrate that the two doctrines do not finally collapse into one.” What this means is that these two things that we were comparing (Deism and Christianity), do not fall into one thing. As in, our natural understanding of God and the special revelation of God through the Bible do not just become one and just a simple harmony.

This is profound! What this philosopher found is that Deism and Christianity are incompatible, but maybe more accurately stated, not able to be combined into one thing. It means that Deism or Christianity - only one of them is right. And this supports my paper in saying that Deism is incorrect, and Christianity is right.

To analyze further, “‘epistemic deism’ ... was meant to capture the view ... the doctrine of ‘noninterventionist special divine action’ (called sometimes NOIDA).” What this is saying is that this epistemic deism is believed to not have supernatural features, as this is opposed by the carnal mind. We see that the philosopher in this paper can only conceive of a God who is normal and who has natural features like gravity that is repeatable. That the supernatural saving of Jericho or the creating of the world through words is too specific and special and unreal - unnatural. We further then see that the Deistic philosopher is guessing in the dark, and that Christianity is knocking on the door with a specific answer.

In particular, this philosopher says that, “God acts in the world without breaking or suspending the laws of nature which He created for the universe. He does not entail breaking or suspending the laws of nature.”

This is a particularly strong argument of the Deist - “Why would God break the laws of the universe, which he created - and created good?” And we see that the Christian answer will always be, “God’s thoughts are higher than our thoughts, and his ways higher than our ways,” and that “God can do as he wills,” and “God is not bound to his creation.” We see that the Christian God cannot be understood through natural human reasoning.

In the next article¹⁰, we see one of the highlights of this paper. One of the great points I wanted to make through this paper is that Deism *is* correct in some sense - that a natural revelation and natural understanding of God is necessary to even understand the special revelation, and also, that it should be congruent to this special revelation. And this following article makes that very clear.

“In eighteenth century England, there were thinkers who said they were Christian deists and claimed pure, original Christianity was deism.” This article states that there were Deists in England who were Christian and Deist - that Christianity is originally, and purely Deistic.

“English deists have the best claim to be considered Christian deists because they alone called themselves Christian deists or called their ideas those of a Christian deist.” And so these people called themselves Christian deists - who combined natural religion with Christianity.

“These three thinkers, Matthew Tindal, Thomas Morgan, and Thomas Amory, developed a theology in which Christianity was deism and natural religion.” We see that at least to these people, that natural religion and Christianity was compatible.

¹⁰ Waligore, Joseph. “Christian Deism in Eighteenth Century England.” *International Journal of Philosophy and Theology* 75, no. 3 (December 31, 2014): 205–22.
doi:10.1080/21692327.2014.959543.

And ultimately, I think that this is just a game of definitions, because according to these Christians, miracles are allowed. It seems to be for the Deist to simply define whether miracles are allowed or not, in making it compatible with Christianity or not. I think that the term “natural religion” is especially loaded with meaning in that the religion is able to be deduced from nature and from observation of life on this earth. And the biggest question I have about this is, “Are we able to correct observe and correctly deduce the religious principles that are the theology of this Deism.”

In conclusion, we see that there are a lot of different Deists. There are Deists who are the youth of today, who believe in a vague conception of God who is not powerful to save or even loving enough to save. And we see writers, like Blake, who believe in Deism and ultimately resort to Epicureanism, which is just a dedication to pleasure. His God is absent and tyrannical. And the philosophers will create a natural religion with a God who cannot do miracles.

According to Postmodernism, which is the era we are in right now, we can honestly not pinpoint a correct answer - for all answers come from a dubitable origin. Thus, my conclusion is: I believe Deism provides a correct natural religion, but this natural religion must be supplanted with special revelation to correctly understand and worship God. The natural religion that can be created can produce mathematics and science, but in terms of religion and philosophy, we need theology and special revelation to correctly deal with these types of questions. Why do I live? Not because of an impersonal God, but because of a personal God who is like a father, who loves me. And so Deism is wrong, and Christianity is correct.

Appendix (Book Report)

The books we read were very helpful for my journey as a minister. Even just yesterday, I was reading Sire's *The Universe Next Door* because I had some time on my hands in church, and I was waiting on the bus. I realized that these books are fun to read, and also provide a perspective that is contradictory to Christianity as it is providing alternate views.

And so Islam was a topic I had to learn recently, and I found it fascinating. I found how Islam is similar to Christianity, yet different in some respects be a challenge to my understanding of God.

And to be relevant to my paper, the chapter titled for Deism in the Sire's book¹¹ was very helpful in helping me understand that standpoint of Deism. I especially found it helpful that it stated that naturalism and natural religion is the main focus of Deism, as it accepts a great God, it just takes out all the supernatural miracles. In some ways, it is very similar to Christianity, as is all religions.

The book by Nagule on Worldviews¹² was especially helpful in understanding the philosophical perspective of the word "worldview" in German. It gave me an understanding that the core of all philosophy is the concept of the worldview and that we need to compare each others' worldviews when we begin our evangelism. Because according to these books, we all have worldviews, and being moral or a decision making human being causes us to have a worldview. And this worldview comes with strings attached - a certain view on metaphysics, epistemology, on anthropology. And thus, it becomes a clash and debate on religion very fast.

¹¹ 1. James W. Sire, *The Universe Next Door: A Basic Worldview Catalog*, 5th ed. (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2009), 45.

¹² 1. David K. Naugle, *Worldview: The History of a Concept* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2002), 87.

I love how Deism is correct in that natural religion is a good way to view religion, but it is wrong in to say that special revelation is not necessary in addition. The reason is because I am a scientist and my dad is much more of a scientist, and I like to understand the world is a rational way, and often times, this can cancel out the characters of good, and love, and kindness. For example, if a chemist is giving a lecture on protons, he will never talk of God's goodness.

And so we see that the Deist is true to his task and skill, but is finding that he canceled out God in his scientific naturalism. And thus, we need to bring the love of God back into the Deists life.

But Naugle's view of Worldview in his book causes me to think that Deists are people who want to understand the world through observation and nature, rather than miracles or strange fantasies that they may call miracles and religion. Thus, I see that Deists have a certain worldview that can be debated with to present the gospel of Christ.

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